Sabra & Co.

7 Ways to Make a Builder-Grade Home Feel Custom

Nothing in a new build was chosen for you. Here's what I'd change, roughly in the order I'd change it.



1 Change the cabinet hardware

KITCHEN + BATHS

The cheapest change in the house, and it shifts a room more than it should.

- [ ] Count every door and drawer before you order.
- [ ] Measure your pulls on center. Most are 3 or 3.75 inches.
- [ ] Pick a shape or finish you love. Basic for basic still reads builder grade.

2 Give the walls some depth

ANY ROOM

This is what makes a room feel built, not assembled. Skip the accent wall.

- [ ] Choose wainscoting, board and batten, or picture frame molding.
- [ ] Run it about two thirds up the wall, not the usual one third.
- [ ] Renting? Most of it comes off. Ask your landlord for the paint color.

3 Replace the bathroom mirrors

BATHS

That plain sheet of glass is the most interchangeable thing in the house.

- [ ] Choose a round mirror or one with real shape. It doesn't need to span the vanity.
- [ ] Budget an hour to patch the wall. Most builder mirrors are glued or clipped on.
- [ ] Hang it lower than instinct says. Not touching the counter, but lower.

4 Update the faucets and fixtures

KITCHEN + BATHS

Generic in almost every new build, and cheaper to replace than people assume.

- [ ] Count the holes. One takes a single handle; three take a widespread or centerset.
- [ ] Measure the spread between the outer holes while you're under there.
- [ ] Budget about $80 to $250 per faucet, plus a few hundred if you hire a plumber.

5 Choose one metal for the house

WHOLE HOUSE

One metal carries the house. The shapes can change room to room.

- [ ] Pick one dominant metal and one accent. I love antique gold with matte black.
- [ ] Keep chrome, nickel and stainless away from gold and brass.
- [ ] Use the same finish in every room, even when the styles are different.

6 Warm up what's cool

WHOLE HOUSE

The view here is already cool. Match it indoors and you never fully relax.

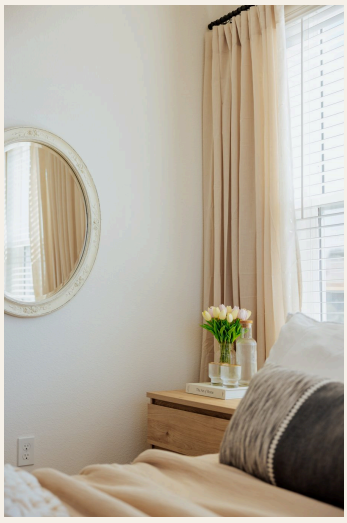
- [ ] Check your floor's undertone before you choose anything else.
- [ ] If your floors are a warm wood, build on them instead of fighting them.
- [ ] Bring in warm wood tones, warm neutrals and one warm metal.

7 Paint or reface the kitchen cabinets

WORTH REAL MONEY

The boxes are usually fine. The plain white doors are what read builder grade.

- [ ] Keep the boxes. A house only a few years old rarely needs new cabinets.
- [ ] Paint is the cheaper route. Move warmer than builder white.
- [ ] Reface if you want a new door style. That's what really breaks the builder look.



Where to start this weekend

If you have a few hundred dollars and a free Saturday:

1. New hardware on the cabinets
2. Something on the walls
3. A different bathroom mirror

Then, when there's room in the budget, paint or reface the cabinet doors.

Want a second set of eyes on your home? I'd love to hear about it.